

MANY-BULBED ORCHID

Dinema polybulbon

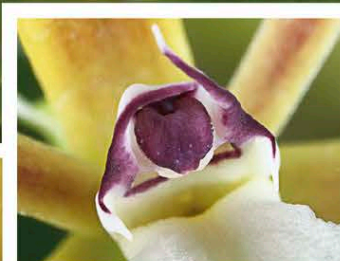
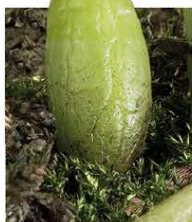
This diminutive orchid is the only species in the genus *Dinema*. Rambling and prolific, it is an epiphytic or lithophytic plant, meaning that it grows on trees or rocks, using them for support. It gains its nutrients from the air, animal detritus, or other plant remains, and absorbs water from rain or mist. Moisture collects on the orchid's leaves, which are thick and waxy, and have reduced stomata — all features which help to reduce water loss. The leaves funnel water into upright, swollen outgrowths from the stems, called pseudobulbs. These act as water-storage organs to keep the orchid hydrated during tropical dry seasons. The creeping stems, with the pseudobulbs, in turn connect to aerial and (sometimes) underground roots. These absorb dissolved nutrients through a spongy, outer layer of cells called velamen. In winter, each pseudobulb produces a single flower. Plants can survive temperatures down to 7°C (45°F), and are a favourite of orchid collectors.

SIZE Height 7.5 cm (3 in)
HABITAT Humid, mixed forests
DISTRIBUTION Mexico, C. America, Jamaica, Cuba
LEAF TYPE Parallel veins



flattened leaf tip
has a notch

PSEUDOBULB >
 These small, oval, bulb-like outgrowths from the creeping stems store water for dry periods. Each produces one to three glossy leaves.



^ FLOWER

The pseudobulb produces a small, sweet-smelling flower with narrow, yellow-brown sepals, purple petals, and a spreading, white lip.

< POLLEN SACS (POLLINIA)

Orchid pollen grains are contained in two sacs. A sticky mass glues the sacs onto pollinating insects, which carry the pollen to another plant.

< AERIAL ROOTS

The orchid's aerial roots need not connect to the soil. The older parts of the root have a protective layer of dead cells that act like blotting paper to absorb and retain water.

